JWT (JSON Web Token) is a compact, self-contained token used to handle user authentication, while Basic HTTP Authentication is a simpler, protocol-level scheme where credentials are sent directly. The main difference comes down to how credentials and state are handled:

Basic HTTP Auth requires the client to send the username and password (encoded in Base64) on every single request. It’s very simple to set up, but it's inefficient and risky for modern apps because credentials are being transmitted repeatedly.

JWT is token-based. The user logs in once, and the server generates a cryptographically signed token. The client stores that token and sends it in the header for subsequent requests. The server just verifies the signature—it's stateless and doesn't need to hit a database every time.